CAT STATS

THE LOWDOWN ON THE CHEETAH, THE FASTEST LAND ANIMAL, WHICH WILL SOON ROAM IN INDIA AFTER ITS EXTINCTION 70 YEARS AGO

Graphic by NILANJAN DAS

AFRICAN CHEETAH

Conservation status: Vulnerable

Family: Felidae

Speed: Maximum 120 kmph

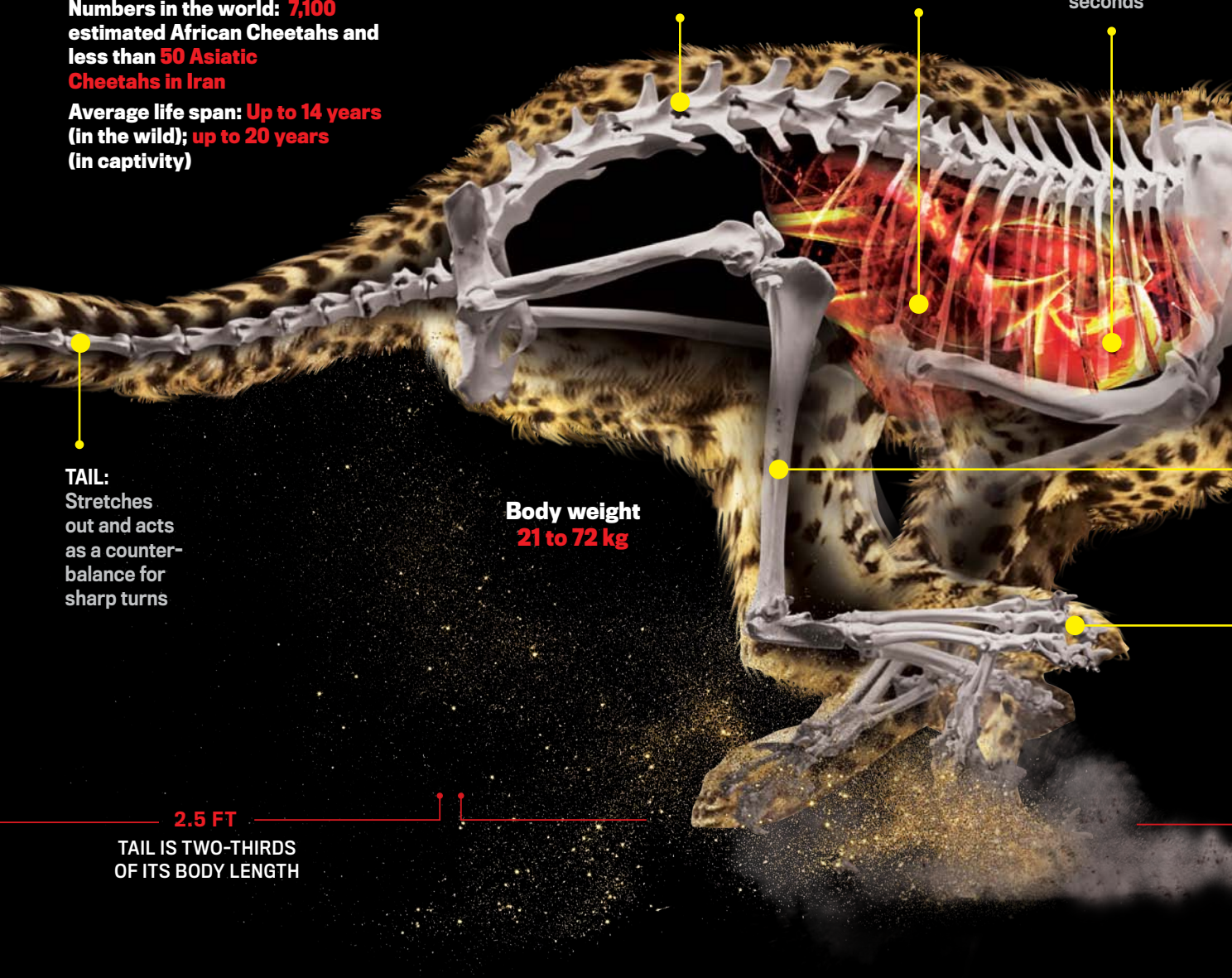
Numbers in the world: 7,100 estimated African Cheetahs and less than 50 Asiatic Cheetahs in Iran

Average life span: Up to 14 years (in the wild); up to 20 years (in captivity)

SPINE: The animal's strongly muscled and hyper-flexible spine helps it maximise stride length

LUNG: An oversize lung and a large heart take in and distribute enormous oxygen to fuel top speed

HEART: The cheetah's heart beat can go up to 250 BPM in just a few seconds



TAIL: Stretches out and acts as a counter-balance for sharp turns

Body weight
21 to 72 kg

2.5 FT
TAIL IS TWO-THIRDS OF ITS BODY LENGTH

1947 The last cheetah hunt is reported from the Koriya princely state in modern-day Chhattisgarh. Three cheetahs were shot by the then ruler Ramanuj Pratap Singh Deo

1952 The cheetah is declared extinct in India, the first such event in free India. Still the only large mammal to go extinct post 1947

1972 India considers introducing Asiatic Cheetahs from Iran. The Shah of Iran, who had agreed to the plan, is deposed and the project falls through

2008 A proposal is submitted to the Union government to bring in the cheetah from Africa

2009 In preliminary site evaluations, Kuno Palpur and Nauradehi in MP and Shahgarh in Rajasthan are identified as potential introduction sites